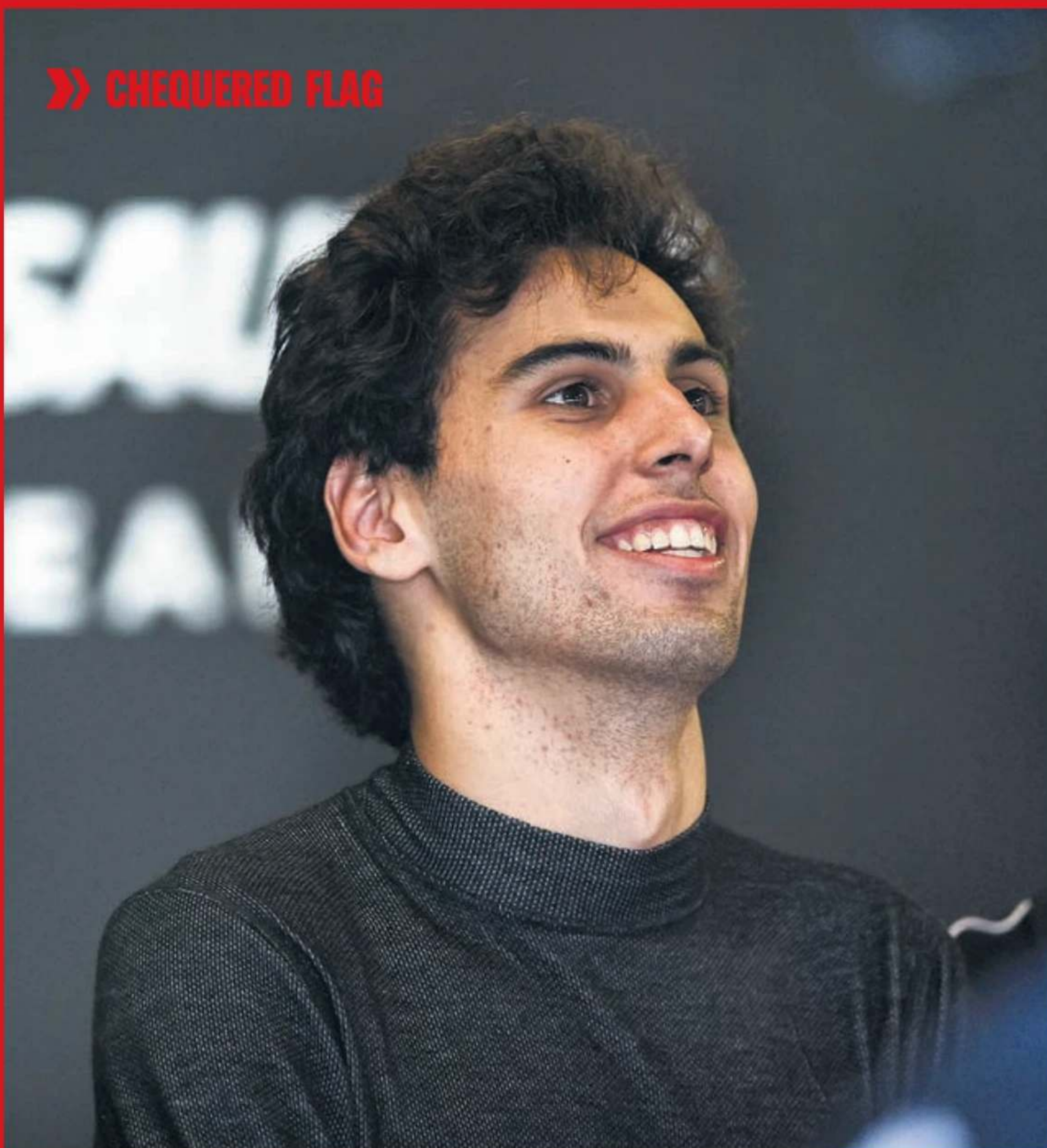




READY TO ROLL

Three rookies are gearing up to take on world champions and competitive drivers, hoping to **secure their futures** in the pinnacle of single-seater racing.

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A new year has rolled in, bringing fresh opportunities, new challenges, and, more importantly, the promise of change. This holds true for the ever-dynamic world of Formula One, which churned out one of its most memorable seasons last time around.

With major rule changes set to take effect from 2026, F1 enters a pivotal high-stakes year that marks both a fresh start and a final shot for the 10 teams, which hope to capitalise on certainties before bracing for the unknown.

As another 24-race spectacle fast approaches, the line-up of 20 drivers will include plenty of familiar faces — some with teams they last raced with, and others behind the wheel of new ones.

This season will also witness the addition of six drivers from

Formula Two, a crucial feeder series that has consistently shone the spotlight on young up-and-coming talent.

While half the lot have added one race to their belts, there are three who are gearing up to get off the mark. As they prepare to take on world champions and competitive drivers, these rookies hope that they can secure their futures in the pinnacle of single-seater racing.

Gabriel Bortoleto

Entering F1 following a less-fancied feeder series title win, Gabriel Bortoleto (**left**) has ensured that a considerable set of eyeballs will be fixated on him as he wades through his maiden season.

He was only the fourth driver in history to win the F3 and F2 titles in consecutive years. Looking at how his predecessors — Charles Leclerc, George Russell, and Oscar Piastri — have already etched their names in history as multiple race winners, Bortoleto will be hoping for a similar script.

His emergence has rekindled the spirit in his home country, Brazil, which has been yearning for a national star since Felipe Massa, who retired in 2017. The 20-year-old also sports an Ayrton Senna-inspired helmet, and need not look much further than the legendary three-time champion for inspiration.

The Brazilian, though, will have his task cut out at Kick Sauber, the team that had the slowest car on the grid in 2024.

As it gears up for a transition into the Audi factory setup in 2026, the upcoming season could be seen as a one-off dead rubber as far as results are concerned.

The former McLaren junior was 'Mr. Consistent' during his time in F2 but will have an able rival in teammate Nico Hulkenberg, who has been one of the midfield superstars since returning to the sport.

Isack Hadjar

Red Bull's junior academy is one of